Colorado Advanced League Referee Quick Guide

Oct 13, 2026 · @Deanna

11U–19U competitive matches (Premier 1–3, Elite, Platinum, Gold, Silver, Bronze and Secondary) under the 2026–27 IFAB Laws of the Game with the CSA changes below (Advanced League Modified LOTG 2026–27). No overtime in league matches.

Age group	Format	Game length	Half-time	Ball	Min. to start/continue	Roster max
11U, 12U	9v9	2 x 30 min	10 min	Size 4	6	16
13U, 14U	11v11	2 x 35 min	10 min	Size 5	7	18
15U	11v11	2 x 40 min	10 min	Size 5	7	18 on game day (22 rostered)
16U (Elite–Bronze)	11v11	2 x 40 min	10 min	Size 5	7	18 on game day (22 rostered)
17U, 18U/19U	11v11	2 x 45 min	10 min	Size 5	7	18 on game day (22 rostered)

Key rules

Item	Rule
Crew (Premier 1–3)	Center + 2 ARs for 13U and older. 11U/12U: one center, ARs if available
Crew (Elite–Bronze)	Center + 2 linesmen for 13U and older. 11U/12U: one center
Secondary division	3 referees per game, matching uniforms
Only two officials	One referees, one runs AR. Club volunteers may run club AR
Mechanics	Diagonal system, one whistle only. Two-whistle games risk fines or loss of game fee

Item	Rule
Substitutions	Unlimited, at any stoppage, with your permission
Leaving the field	Subbed-off player has 10 seconds. Too slow: the sub waits until the first stoppage after 1 minute
Uniforms	When colors clash, home (listed first) wears dark, visitors light (opposite of National 1). Keepers change as you direct
Equipment	No earrings (silicone flat-back protectors OK), no hard hair clips. Taping is not allowed
Ball	Each team brings one or more; you pick
Goalkeeper hands	Max 8 seconds. Count down the last 5 visibly; over time = corner kick to opponents
Throw-in delay	Whistle, count 5 visibly; over time = throw-in to opponents
Goal kick delay	Whistle, count 5 visibly; keeper still holding = corner kick to opponents
Field fitness	Your call is final. Permit holders can still close a field
Weather	Match counts as complete if the first half was finished; otherwise it is replayed
Overtime	None in league play

Before the match

Check-in

- Introduce yourself to each coach and ask for the team roster.
- Verify every player and coach against the electronic roster or approved digital player pass.
- No valid roster? Let the game go ahead. Get a written list of players' names and numbers from that coach, tell the other coach, and send CSA a detailed report. It is not grounds for a protest.

- Note anyone sitting out a suspension; you'll confirm it in the game report.
- Inspect every player's equipment.

Forfeits

- A team not ready 10 minutes after the scheduled start can be forfeited.
- A coach or team representative must be present within 10 minutes of kickoff.

Field and sideline

- Goals anchored. 11U–12U goals 6.5′ x 18.5′ or 7′ x 21′; 13U–19U goals 8′ x 24′. Cones and flags are not proper markings.
- Both teams on one side; spectators on the other when feasible. The home coach picks sides; you enforce it.
- Spectators at least 5 feet from touchlines and goal lines (or behind a spectator line). No one behind the goal lines unless seated in bleachers.
- Max 4 credentialed coaches per team on the sideline.

Discipline

Send-off minimums (you report; CSA enforces) — CSA League Rules & Procedures 2025–26

Reason for send-off	Minimum suspension
Serious foul play	1 game
DOGSO, or deliberate handball to deny a goal	1 game
Second caution	1 game
Offensive/abusive language	1 game (frustration) or 2 games (directed at a person)
Violent conduct or spitting	2 games
Pushing or striking a referee or AR in aggression	1 year (5 years if serious injury)
Refusing or faking a name	At least 1 more game

- **Yellow cards:** 5 stand-alone cautions in any 365 days = automatic 1-game suspension. Cautions from non-league events don't count.
- **Sent-off player:** not replaced; the team plays short.
- **Coaches:** you may warn, caution or send off team officials for irresponsible behavior. A parent may step in if a coach is sent off.
- **Disruptive spectators or participants:** stop play; they must move at least 100 yards away. If they don't comply within 2 minutes, you may end the match, and that team may forfeit.
- **Abuse from the touchline:** report it as misconduct (caution or send-off level) under the U.S. Soccer Referee Abuse Prevention Policy.

After the match

- [ ] Confirm with your crew every caution, send-off and misconduct: who, which team, what offense.
- [ ] Return team documents to the coaches.
- [ ] Enter the final score and game report in Assignr.com within 24 hours: cautions, send-offs, serious injuries and completed sit-outs.
- [ ] Report unsporting or disruptive spectator behavior.
- [ ] Game not played but you were there? File an incident report explaining why.
- [ ] Keep your notes; you may be asked to explain an incident at a hearing.

Reports later than 48 hours, or missing key details, can bring a fine and loss of the game fee.